own principle of maintaining short communication lines. This allowed Thorat's detractors to accuse the Eastern Army Commander of making grand plans based on theoretical knowledge.

Later, Palit was to concede that it was a big mistake to ignore what Thorat was saying at that time. As the army commander, Thorat subsequently toured the various sectors; to zero in on his lack of ground knowledge in 1959 was grossly unfair. Thorat would have had no choice but to make his entire plan by studying the terrain on a map, for prior to the Dalai Lama's escape from Tibet in 1959, the government refused to entertain his suggestion that responsibility for the NEFA region (very different from manning the border, as announced by Nehru in Parliament in August 1959) be given to the army. There was so much acrimony and controversy over the 'proper border defence' at the time, the very fact that Thimayya supported this suggestion may well have hardened Krishna Menon's stand against it.

However, not one to give up easily, Thorat went and met Krishna Menon in Delhi. In his usual dismissive and sarcastic style, the defence minister said that there would be no war between India and China, and in the most unlikely event of there being one, he was quite capable of fighting it himself on a diplomatic level.

This period also coincided with Nehru's recent new administrative venture in keeping with Verrier Elwin's 'Philosophy for NEFA' that was aimed at protecting the primitive tribal people from a precipitate exposure to the commercial and often venal culture of the plainsmen. The last thing Nehru would have then wanted was to have the army swarming into the region. With the Assam Rifles it was different—the force had always blended in with the local people and was, in fact, an essential part of the tribal experiment.

Delhi's refusal to look north was extremely frustrating for Thorat. 'He knew the army would be left holding the can the moment the balloon went up, and go up it surely would,' said his son, Yashwant, nearly four decades later. 'Father was somewhat influenced by the US Army's tactics in Korea where the 37th Parallel became the sacrosanct dividing line.' Thorat was determined not to allow the enemy to cross the defensive line. He would explain to anyone who was still willing to listen: 'This line will divide NEFA into two halves. The area north of the defence line shall be known as the Northern Sector and the area south of it as the Southern Sector. This is